

Treatise I.iii.xiv**1 Hume and his opponents**

- (1) ‘I begin with observing that the terms of *efficacy*, *agency*, *power*, *force*, *energy*, *necessity*, *connexion*, and *productive quality*, are all nearly synonymous. . . .’ (157)
- (2) In order to “place” a power in “some particular being”, we must “distinctly and particularly conceive the connexion betwixt the cause and effect, and be able to pronounce, from a simple view of the one, that it must be follow’d or preceded by the other. . . . Which kind of connexion has already been rejected in all cases.” (161–162)

Thus, Hume takes his opponents to hold that our causal beliefs involve ideas which violate the Separability Principle.

- (3) Two categories of opponents:
 - (i) “Naive empiricists” or “the vulgar”. They think that we acquire these Separability-violating ideas directly in ordinary sensory perception.
 - (ii) “Rationalists” or “false philosophers”. They agree with Hume that *impressions* obey the Separability Principle, at least in ordinary cases, but hold that we can (and should, if we want to believe the truth) form *ideas* which don’t obey the principle.
- (4) Hume’s arguments against his opponents (besides simply restating the Separability Principle).
 - (i) The vulgar view he takes to be easily refuted by doing some simple thought experiments (e.g. imagining billiard balls behaving in strange ways).
 - (ii) He argues against the false philosophers’ view by appealing to the Copy Principle.
(In the appendix (623–633) he considers a sophisticated version of the false philosopher’s view which attempts to respect the Copy Principle.)
- (5) How can we explain the opponents’ tendencies to make these mistakes?
We confuse ‘hard to separate’ with ‘inseparable’.
‘the mind has a great propensity to spread itself on external objects’ . . . (167).

2 Hume’s positive view

- (6) Although words like ‘power’, ‘necessary connexion’, ‘causation’ are misused by the opponents, they are not completely meaningless (162). There really is a distinctive mental

phenomenon of having beliefs about causation.

- (7) An example: Joe and Harry have both just now experienced lightning and thunder. Joe has never been in a thunderstorm before; he does not know that lightning is generally followed by thunder; the thunder took him by surprise, when it occurred; he has no tendency to move from the idea of the lightning to the idea of the thunder; if another lightning were to occur, he wouldn't expect another thunder. Harry is unlike Joe in all these respects.

Also, Harry does and Joe does not believe that the lightning was the cause of the thunder. Suggestion: according to Hume, this latter psychological difference between Harry and Joe is not some *further* difference between them; rather, it is no more than another way of talking about some or all of the differences on the first list.

'The necessary connexion betwixt causes and effects is the foundation of our inference from one to the other. The foundation of our inference is the transition arising from the accustomed union. These are, therefore, the same.' (165)

- (8) The two definitions of cause (169–170).

Puzzle: how can the same notion have two apparently non-equivalent definitions?

Garrett's solution: 'cause' is an abstract idea; a 'definition' of an abstract idea is just any principle which distinguishes the ideas in its revival set from those that aren't in it.

Puzzle: doesn't the second definition make it impossible for us to be wrong about causation?

Garrett's solution: both definitions can be taken in a 'subjective' sense and an 'objective' or 'idealised' sense.

3 The impression of necessary connexion

- (9) In the foregoing account of Hume's positive view, there is no mention of a special 'impression of necessary connexion'. Nevertheless, Hume does talk about such an impression, and says some very puzzling things about it:

(i) It is an 'internal impression, or impression of reflexion' (165)

(ii) It *is* the determination of the mind to pass from the idea of one thing to the idea of another.

—Seems like a category mistake!

(iii) Hume's opponents' errors are explained by the 'spreading' of this impression onto the external world.

—but why would this mistake lead to the mistake of supposing one's ideas to violate Separability?

- (iv) In fact, this impression is ‘incompatible’ with the ideas of external objects.
—why should this be? If I ‘spread’ the impression of pleasure onto my slice of chocolate cake, I might be believing something *false*, but am I really believing something *incoherent*? And in any case, the ‘spreading’ is supposed to be just as bad in the case of *mental* causes as in the case of *physical* causes.
- (10) My solution: Hume was confused when he talked about the idea of necessary connection as being derived from a distinctive sort of impression. He got himself into this confusion by (i) applying the Copy Principle in an overly literal-minded way to abstract ideas, and (ii) by failing to be clear about the distinction between the notion of “feeling” (as in ‘belief is a feeling’) and the notion of an impression—a failure which is remedied in the *Appendix*.